

English Vocabulary Builder

Kelvin Yang

May 8, 2026

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Chapter 1

4k-Level

1.1 The Museum Project

When Ms. Hart asked us to design a new museum exhibition, she began with a **questionnaire**. She wanted to know what visitors liked: science, history, music, politics, animals, or old machines. The answers were placed on a metal **rack** beside the door, where anyone could read them. At first, I did not want to **dwell** on the details, but soon I saw that every answer revealed a small world.

The exhibition was called “A Small **realm** of Human Life.” One room showed the crown of a forgotten **monarch**, together with notes from the old **legislature**. Another room was about **astronomy**; a child with a bandaged **ankle** stood under the painted stars and asked why the moon seemed to **rotate** around us. Our school had a fixed **quota** of visitors, so everyone had to **conform** to the timetable and **comply** with the safety rules.

The museum itself had a strange history. Its **predecessor** was a public library, and before that it had been a poor **dwelling** for workers who cut **timber**. A photograph near the entrance was so old that the faces had begun to **blur**; still, you could see a man’s tired **forehead**, a woman holding a pa-

questionnaire 問卷

rack 架子

dwell 居住

realm 領域

monarch 君主

legislature 立法機關

astronomy 天文學

ankle 腳踝

rotate 旋轉

quota 限額

conform 遵從

comply 遵守

predecessor 前身

dwell 居住

timber 木材

blur 模糊

forehead 前額

packet 小包

bundle 一捆

cord 繩子

ink 墨水

discard 丟棄
fond 喜愛的
olive 橄欖
mammal 哺乳動物
barn 穀倉
beneficial 有益的
cultivate 培養
recycle 回收
aluminium 鋁
wax 蠟
fork 叉子
sleeve 袖子
textile 紡織品
faction 派系
conspiracy 陰謀
fine 罰款
exile 流亡
sergeant 軍士
ballot 選票
sentence 判刑
torture 酷刑
regain 重獲
obscure 掩蓋
toxic 有害的
bullet 子彈
foresee 預見
obstacle 障礙
surgeon 外科醫生
hardware 器械
horizontal 水平的
vertical 垂直的
oxygen 氧氣
particle 微粒
impair 損害
miracle 奇蹟

per **packet**, and a child standing near a **bundle** of books tied with a **cord**. On a small label, someone had written in blue **ink**: “Do not **discard** memory too quickly.”

Our guide, Mr. Lane, was **fond** of strange connections. In the agricultural room, he spoke about **olive** trees, **mammal** bones found near an old **barn**, and the **beneficial** effects of teaching children to **cultivate** a garden. He also explained how people learned to **recycle** metal, glass, and **aluminium**, and how old **wax** tablets could preserve writing. He said that even a broken **fork**, a torn **sleeve**, or a piece of **textile** could help historians understand daily life.

In the political room, the story became darker. There had once been a violent **faction** that spread a **conspiracy** about the royal family. Some people were **fined**, and others were forced into **exile**. A serious **sergeant** stood in one photograph, guarding a box of **ballot** papers. Nearby, a judge’s notes described a harsh **sentencing** hearing, a case of **torture**, and the attempt of one prisoner to **regain** his dignity. The museum did not try to **obscure** these events. Instead, it showed how fear can become **toxic**, how a single **bullet** can change a city, and how no government can **foresee** every **obstacle** that history will place before it.

Still, the exhibition was not hopeless. The next room was about medicine. A famous **surgeon** had once worked there after a war. On display were his **hardware** tools, a **horizontal** table, a **vertical** chart, and a diagram showing how **oxygen** moves through the body. A model of a lung showed tiny **particles** in the air. The surgeon believed that illness could **impair** the body, but kindness could heal the mind. He used to say that survival was not a **miracle**; it was the result of skill, care, and patience.

The science room had a more playful tone. It compared **physics** with daily experience. One machine used **copper**

wire and a glass **dome**; another machine tried to **align** light through a small hole. A child asked whether a **hybrid** car belonged in the science room or the social room. Mr. Lane laughed and said that this was the museum's central **paradox**: every object belonged to more than one category. Even a simple map could become a **metaphor** for human choices.

At noon, we ate in the museum café. It was designed to **cater** to students, elderly people, and tourists. The food was not **premium**, but it was warm. A singer from the local **choir** performed a short **solo**; later, a small **jazz** group played near the window. A little girl sat on her father's **lap**, watching the sunlight **gleam** on a marble statue. The **bride** in a wedding photograph wore a thin **veil**; on the **eve** of her marriage, she had donated her family letters to the museum.

In the technology room, there were old **telecom** devices, a wooden phone box, and early computer parts. A sign explained that digital **literacy** was now as important as reading paper books. Some devices looked **dim** and ugly, but visitors were **ambitious** enough to try them. One screen suddenly made a loud **jerk**, then went black. A boy almost took a **tumble**, but he caught the edge of a table. The staff member in charge had to **administer** a quick check and then put a warning sign near the **exit**.

In a side gallery, the museum showed how art and society often overlap. One poster discussed the history of **homosexual** identity and the struggle for public recognition. Another exhibit asked why some societies **classify** people too quickly, turning living individuals into fixed types. Mr. Lane said that a museum should not **preoccupy** visitors with labels alone. "A label can help," he said, "but it can also become a **foul** habit if it replaces thought." We took a slow **stroll** through the gallery, and I began to understand that the **pursuit** of knowledge was not the same as the possession of it.

physics 物理學

copper 銅

dome 圓頂

align 對齊

hybrid 混合型的

paradox 悖論

metaphor 隱喻

cater 迎合

premium 高級的

choir 合唱團

solo 獨唱

jazz 爵士樂

lap 膝上

gleam 閃光

bride 新娘

veil 面紗

eve 前夕

telecom 電信

literacy 素養

dim 昏暗的

ambitious 有抱負的

jerk 急動

tumble 跌倒

administer 施行

exit 出口

homosexual 同性戀的

classify 分類

preoccupy 佔據心思

foul 惡劣的

stroll 散步

pursuit 追求

spectacular 壯觀的

temple 神殿

marble 大理石

bathe 沐浴

commodity 商品
insult 侮辱
beast 野獸
arena 公共舞臺
auction 拍賣
recipient 接受者
defect 缺陷
fame 名聲
eligible 有資格的
affiliate 使附屬

The last room was the most **spectacular**. It looked like a stone **temple**, with a white **marble** floor and a painted sky above. Visitors could **bathe** their hands in a shallow basin of light, not water. A sign asked them to place each object into one group: tool, artwork, weapon, **commodity**, or sacred object. Some people argued. One man called the task an **insult**; another said that a museum should never treat a sacred image like a **beast** in a cage. Mr. Lane quietly said that disagreement was part of the public **arena**.

Before we left, the museum held a small charity **auction**. Each **recipient** of a donated object had written a short note about why it mattered. One case contained a broken toy, a cracked cup, and a note about a manufacturing **defect**. The objects were not famous; they had no **fame** at all. Yet the label said that every ordinary object had an **eligible** place in history if it helped someone understand the past. The museum was **affiliated** with a university, but it did not speak only to experts. It asked ordinary visitors to look carefully, think slowly, and remember that the past is never only one story.

1.2 The Cave Archive

When the old railway museum received a bundle of papers from a mountain town, the director hoped the files would arrive **intact**. They did not. A yellow **fax** from twenty years before lay on top, but the ink had blurred, and a rusted **spike** from the abandoned track had torn a corner from a handwritten **verse**. The author was **anonymous**; he used old pronouns like **thou** and wrote some nouns in strange **plural** forms. Beside the papers was a dry **mushroom**, a **crude** map, and a small **cartoon** of a man with a huge **chin**. It looked **comic**, but Dr. Lane, an **amateur** historian with serious habits, re-

intact 完整的
fax 傳真
spike 尖釘
verse 詩句
anonymous 匿名的
thou 你
plural 複數
mushroom 蘑菇
crude 粗糙的
cartoon 漫畫
chin 下巴

fused to laugh.

The story led us to a **cave** above the town. Local memory said that the **predominant** use of the cave had once been storage, but no clear **classification** existed for the objects inside. A hunter had seen **deer** near the entrance, and the first **scenario** we imagined was simple: smugglers had hidden commodities there. Yet each new clue seemed to **diminish** that theory. The museum had to **repay** a small grant if the project failed, so we tried to **fuse** careful research with practical speed. Our only **trophy** would be knowledge.

The town council agreed to **furnish** lamps, **mats**, and basic hardware. The first **sensation** inside the cave was cold air mixed with the **odour** of damp stone and old **ash**. A child from the school choir watched a dog **lick** water from a shallow pool, then **stagger** away when a bat rushed past his forehead. We planned to **excavate** only a narrow area, because eggs might still **hatch** in nests near the roof. Nobody wanted his **ego** to become bigger than the cave itself.

The university **chancellor** visited on the second morning. She stood beside a broken **statue** and asked about the **duration** of the work. I showed her a **diagram** in which vertical shafts **complement** horizontal passages. On a folding table stood cheap **champagne**, a rubber mat, a **hammer**, and a fork someone had used for lunch. We tried to spread the lights **evenly**, but one bulb began to **explode** with tiny sparks, so a sergeant from the safety team cut the cord and replaced it.

At the back of the cave we found a rack of manuscripts and a small packet of letters. Their writer had a deep **longing** to regain fame. He had drawn a cartoon showing a medieval engineer seeking a **patent** for a rotating machine. The papers also contained a **medieval array** of symbols: a crown, a **pope**, a **butterfly**, a **bolt**, and a **spoon**. Marta raised one **eyebrow**; the pattern seemed obscure. Dust made her **choke**, and she

comic 滑稽的

amateur 業餘的

cave 洞穴

predominant 主要的

classification 分類

deer 鹿

scenario 情景

diminish 減少

repay 償還

fuse 融合

trophy 獎品

furnish 提供

mat 墊子

sensation 感覺

odour 氣味

ash 灰

lick 舔

stagger 踉蹌

excavate 挖掘

hatch 孵化

ego 自尊

chancellor 校長

statue 雕像

duration 持續時間

diagram 圖表

complement 補充

champagne 香檳

hammer 錘子

evenly 均勻地

explode 爆裂

longing 渴望

patent 專利

medieval 中世紀的

array 一系列

pope 教宗

butterfly 蝴蝶
bolt 螺栓
spoon 湯匙
eyebrow 眉毛
choke 噎住
deprive 剝奪
linguistic 語言的
legacy 遺產
socialist 社會主義的
satisfactory 令人滿意的
boast 吹噓
ridge 山脊
emperor 皇帝
comparative 比較的
bruise 瘀傷
organism 生物
integrity 誠信
stack 堆
obsess 著迷
betray 背叛
overnight 過夜
fare 車費
infrastructure 基礎設施
grim 嚴峻的
signature 簽名
abundant 豐富的
pledge 承諾
passive 被動的
applicable 適用的
viable 可行的
bulb 燈泡
privatise 私有化
patrol 巡邏

said the cave should not **deprive** anyone of oxygen for the sake of an old metaphor.

My task was **linguistic**. I compared the strange verse with temple inscriptions and with a questionnaire from a literacy project. The language showed the **legacy** of several realms: a monarch's court, a **socialist** printing club, and a church choir. Some translations were not **satisfactory**, because the writer loved to **boast** and to conceal ordinary facts under grand words. From a **ridge** above the town, he compared himself to an **emperor**; in a **comparative** note, he called his predecessor only a beast. That insult told us more about his character than about history.

The third day brought danger. A student slipped on marble dust and got a **bruise** on his ankle. Near him, a wet wall held a living **organism** that no one could classify. To preserve scientific **integrity**, we refused to discard it as mere mould. We made a **stack** of samples and labelled them carefully. One assistant began to **obsess** over a possible conspiracy, claiming that the writer had tried to **betray** his faction. Dr. Lane told him to sleep **overnight** before making any inference.

By morning the cave had become an arena of debate. The bus **fare** for students was low, yet the town's **infrastructure** was weak, and the road was almost impassable after rain. Someone found a manuscript about an old pope, written beside a drawing of a butterfly. Another page gave a **grim** warning: "If thou break this pledge, the mountain will fall." Beneath it was a **signature**, still clear in copper-coloured ink. The valley had **abundant** timber, but its people had made a **pledge** not to cut the forest around the cave.

The council did not want to remain **passive**. They asked whether the warning was **applicable** to modern law, and whether the museum could turn the site into a **viable** education centre. We replaced each weak **bulb**, tightened every bolt, and

marked the exit. At supper, an accountant joked that even a spoon from the cave would be put in an auction. The mayor disliked the joke because some officials wanted to **privatise** the land. A night **patrol** was arranged to prevent theft.

That conflict **compelled** us to speak openly. If the town tried to **conceal** the finds, the loss would be of great **magnitude**. The chancellor offered to **endow** an **interim** archive, but warned us not to let a **con** grow around local pride. Her **outlook** was practical: begin with a **shallow** excavation, then **opt** for deeper work only after a full report. Her words lit a **spark** in the room, though not everyone was pleased.

The doctor from the clinic added another issue. Dust in the cave could cause **acute** breathing problems, and one volunteer had **diabetes**, so long hours without food were unsafe. We **refined** the schedule into small **chunks** of time and wrote elementary rules on the wall: drink water, leave when dizzy, and never work alone near the **dock** by the underground pool. A **rap** group from the school offered to make a song about the project, but the teacher feared that rap would make the discovery seem too sensational. The students argued that music could help every **constituency** in town feel included.

In the final report, I tried to **infer** where the whole tradition might **originate**. The answer still **fascinates** me. A medieval craftsman may have hidden his designs there, and later readers added verse, political notes, and religious symbols. We had to refine this theory again and again, because a single defect could impair the whole argument. Yet the conclusion was strong enough for an **elementary** exhibition: a cave once used for storage became a place where poetry, technology, faith, and local politics met. Its legacy was not a miracle, but something more useful: a patient record of how ordinary people tried to preserve their world.

compel 迫使

conceal 隱瞞

magnitude 重大性

endow 資助

interim 臨時的

con 騙局

outlook 觀點

shallow 淺的

opt 選擇

spark 火花

acute 急性的

diabetes 糖尿病

refine 完善

chunk 塊

dock 碼頭

rap 說唱

constituency 選民群體

infer 推斷

originate 起源

fascinate 吸引

elementary 初級的

Avenue 大道
greenhouse 溫室
landlord 房東
fraud 欺詐
Ms 女士
anniversary 周年紀念
poster 海報
script 腳本
rigour 嚴格
preliminary 初步的
clay 黏土
mould 模具
sodium 鈉
dioxide 二氧化物
simulate 模擬
rocket 火箭
terminal 終端
vibrate 震動
stab 刺
slot 狹槽
scramble 匆忙行動
peculiar 奇特的
murmur 低語
ladder 梯子
wrist 手腕
batter 連續擊打
crumble 碎裂
Amid 在……之中
armour 盔甲
primitive 原始的
optic 視覺的；光學的
needle 針
confidential 機密的

1.3 The Town Inquiry

On the edge of North **Avenue** stood a broken research house that everyone simply called the old **greenhouse**. For years it had been locked by a suspicious **landlord**, and rumours about **fraud**, strange experiments, and missing public money moved through the town like smoke. When **Ms** Hart, our history teacher, asked our class to prepare an **anniversary** exhibition about the place, she did not want a dramatic **poster** or a comic **script**. She wanted evidence, order, and **rigour**.

Our **preliminary** visit began in the yard, where **clay** pots lay under a rusted rack and a wooden **mould** had grown dark with damp. A chemistry table still held a label for **sodium** and another for carbon **dioxide**, while a cracked **simulator** stood beside a model **rocket**. Its **terminal** screen was dead, but a careless touch made its engine **vibrate**, and we all stepped back. “Do not **stab** at the buttons,” Ms Hart said, pointing at a narrow **slot** in the panel. We had to **scramble** for notebooks because the machine began to make a **peculiar murmur**, as if it still remembered its old work.

Inside, a **ladder** led to a storage room above the laboratory. We climbed slowly, mindful of every **wrist** and ankle, because the steps were **battered** and the floor seemed ready to **crumble**. **Amid** the dust, we found **armour** from a school play, a **primitive optical** device, and a box of **needles** used in plant experiments. There was also a **confidential** file labelled “**abnormal** growth.” It described how one scientist tried to simulate disease in leaves, then claimed that a **clone** of a rare plant could save the town’s economy. The idea had **relevance**, but the method seemed careless.

Ms Hart asked me to **compile** a list of objects while Lena took photographs. I wrote down clay, mould, sodium, dioxide, and **mineral** samples; then I noted **grease** on the old **keyboard** and a sharp **lemon** smell from a sealed bottle. A

physician's note warned that one worker's **liver** had begun to **deteriorate** after **prolonged** exposure to chemicals. The note was not a final diagnosis, but its tone was **stern**. It also said that alcohol, especially **whiskey**, had been found in the office, though nobody knew whether it belonged to the workers or to the landlord.

The town archive helped us understand the wider story. A **capitalist** company had once tried to build a **monopoly** over a new seed variety. Its managers **aspired** to fame and spoke of a **mighty** future, but their **hierarchy** was brutal. Workers **marched** through the avenue in protest, saying the company would **displace** small farmers and **oppress** anyone who refused to comply. Some residents **deemed** the protest unnecessary; others saw it as a **sincere** attempt to defend **ecological** life. The debate gained **momentum**, and the company's public image began to deteriorate.

The most moving document was a letter from an old gardener. He did not write like a scholar, yet the **essence** of his argument was clear: "A plant is not a **proposition** in a **thesis**; it lives in soil, water, light, and care." He asked readers to **contemplate** whether progress without justice could ever be called progress. He also warned against **prejudice** toward poor labourers, because some officials had called them **idle**, **arrogant**, or even used the offensive word **bastard**. Ms Hart **frowned** when she read that line, and said such language was meant to **humiliate** people.

At **supper** that evening, our group met in a small café near the dock. The owner had **brewed** tea with **spice** and lemon, and the warm smell helped us relax. We discussed the **dual** purpose of our exhibition: it had to tell a **straightforward** story, but it also had to show the **infinite** complexity behind one public scandal. Tom wanted to **omit** the painful parts, especially the **fatal** accident in which a worker fell from a roof

abnormal 異常的
clone 克隆
relevance 相關性
compile 彙編
mineral 礦物
grease 油脂
keyboard 鍵盤
lemon 檸檬
physician 醫生
liver 肝臟
deteriorate 惡化
prolong 延長
stern 嚴厲的
whiskey 威士忌
capitalist 資本主義的；
 資本家
monopoly 壟斷
aspire 渴望
mighty 強大的
hierarchy 等級制度
march 行進
displace 取代；迫使離
 開
oppress 壓迫
deem 認為
sincere 真誠的
ecological 生態的
momentum 勢頭
essence 本質
proposition 命題
thesis 論題；論文
contemplate 沉思
prejudice 偏見
idle 閒置的；懶散的
arrogant 傲慢的

bastard 私生子；混蛋

frown 皺眉

humiliate 羞辱

supper 晚餐

brew 沖泡；釀造

spice 香料

dual 雙重的

straightforward 直截了當的

infinite 無限的

omit 省略

fatal 致命的

blaze 火焰

deter 阻止

erupt 爆發

despatch 派遣；發送

detain 拘留；扣留

veterinarian 獸醫

wreck 毀壞

box 裝箱；拳擊

cult 崇拜；邪教

gospel 福音

superb 極好的

obstruct 阻礙

illuminate 照亮；闡明

ancestor 祖先

owl 貓頭鷹

blink 眨眼

minimal 最小的

stance 立場

stitch 縫線；縫合

pulse 脈搏

furious 憤怒的

comprehend 理解

loom 隱約出現

during a **blaze**. I disagreed. To **deter** future negligence, we had to include what people would rather forget.

The accident report was hard to read. It said the fire **erupted** after a lamp fell into grease, and the blaze spread through dry timber. A worker tried to **despatch** a warning by fax, but the line failed. Others were **detained** by locked doors, and one man survived only because a **veterinarian** from the next street broke a window and pulled him out. The fire destroyed the laboratory but did not **wreck** every record. Some papers were **boxed** in metal cases; others were saved by a woman who later became a local councillor.

We also discovered a strange cultural layer. A small **cult** of admirers had formed around the chief scientist after his death. They treated his notes like a **gospel**, repeating every claim without question. In one notebook he had written, "The old world must be remade." This sounded **superb** to some readers, but to us it seemed dangerous. It could **obstruct** ordinary judgement. Ms Hart said that a slogan can **illuminate** an age, but it can also conceal the damage done by those who think their own vision is pure.

Near the end of the project, we invited the town's oldest resident to speak. Her **ancestor** had worked in the greenhouse. She remembered stories of **owls** in the roof, of workers who boxed in the courtyard after work, and of an engineer who could not **blink** when he was angry. She laughed at some memories, then became quiet. "People thought the case was simple," she said. "It was not. There was hope, fear, money, science, and human pride. That is why you must not make the exhibition too **minimal**."

Her words shaped our final **stance**. We placed the clay pots near the chemical labels, the worker's letter beside the company contract, and the accident report under a dim lamp. We used **stitches** of red thread to connect photographs, maps,

and testimony. The thread looked almost like a **pulse** running through the display. Above it, our main poster asked one question: “What happens when ambition loses its care for people?”

On opening day, the exhibition hall was full. Some visitors were **furious** because we had not praised the company’s achievements enough. Others said the display was honest. The landlord stood at the back, silent, while the old greenhouse appeared on the screen behind him. For a moment nobody spoke. Then Ms Hart gave a small nod. Our work had not solved every problem, but it had made the town **comprehend** why the past still **loomed** over the present.